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The social media landscape: new media and 'old' media

One starting point from which to gain insights into the transformations represented by new media is a consideration of the use and consequences of older media. Take, for example, the television, where programmes that dominate household viewing in Trinidad are typically the six-o'clock news and the show following it, *Crime Watch*. The television is a constant presence in many homes, with watching a programme and discussing it around dinner time a key component of evening sociality.¹ By the end of the field work, some homes also had smart televisions in addition to cable. For the last ten years, even the less well-off households have had cable television, as for most of Trinidad's population, ownership of a television and a basic mobile phone is readily accessible, including among lower-income groups who may not own a car and who live in basic housing.

The main reason for this is not low cost, but the fact that individuals live in extended networks of family and friends. Although they might not be able to buy the newest televisions or phones themselves, they are likely to have relatives who can and who pass goods such as televisions and phones on to them. The possession of a television in itself implies sharing, but so too does the experience of watching the news and programmes such as *Crime Watch*. Most people have a preference for watching well known programmes so that there is more to talk and to share opinions about. Viewing television is thus not a passive activity, but one appropriated to feed the social demands of family and wider networks. The engagement generates a stronger sense of being collective, which is the setting for understanding social media in turn.

Following this trajectory, this chapter examines what social media represents in the town of El Mirador by looking at the historical precedence for what social media might be for Trinidadians more generally.

The use of communications and social media is best understood when contextualised by wider, 'offline' themes reflected in Trinidadian face-to-face relations. Accordingly, this chapter will introduce the local idioms of 'maco' and 'bacchanal' to show how these understandings extend to more traditional forms of mass media, such as news coverage and television soap operas, as well as how the logic of these idioms is continued through the use of social media. In El Mirador, people do not simply talk about the programmes they regularly view: they also use them to affirm the key values and practices of Trinidadian society. The issue of access also relates to the idea of 'polymedia' – a term coined by Madianou and Miller, which will become important in this chapter as well as in understanding social relationships in Chapter 4.² Here polymedia is used to describe the relationship of social media to the wider ecology of more 'mass' or mainstream media and its recent history in Trinidad. As is discussed further in Chapter 4 in relation to the development of new media and the introduction of platforms such as Skype, Facebook and WhatsApp, as issues of cost and access have decreased, social and moral judgements as to choices of communication platform have increased.

This present chapter, as well as Chapter 3, sketches some background for Trinidadian society, in particular detailing how the intersections of ethnicity, class and gender have expressed themselves in social media. Class, for example, has manifested through commercial uses of Facebook, where pages for business try to brand themselves for young, more affluent and urban-oriented patrons. On this theme, the chapter concludes with a discussion of social divisions in El Mirador. For although Trinidad is a resource-rich country with initiatives such as 'one laptop per child', the digital divide in this region remains one of information rather than infrastructure.

Mainstream media in Trinidad

Trinidadian household television, cable networks and now the rise of Netflix with smart televisions reflect the intersection of media influences from the US, Latin America and Bollywood. In the 1980s and 1990s Trinidad could be described more as a cultural receiver than cultural producer, with US media dominating its television screens.³ McFarlane-Alvarez describes the media landscape of the last decade as one in which films and television programmes from the US outnumbered local media productions broadcast on local screens. At the time of her study in 2004,

Trinidad had 19 cinemas with 30 screens, 70 cable channels and only three local channels.⁴ There is still no notable film industry and the number of locally produced television programmes is limited (most are news-related or panel discussions).⁵

Just as audiences will watch the same shows at the time they are broadcast on commercial television for discussion afterwards, going to the cinema in Trinidad is an equally social experience. Outside of Port of Spain, the cinema is still a relatively cheap pastime at around TT \$20 (USD \$3.30) per ticket, and the decision to go is based more on wanting to socialise in a group, rather than wanting to watch a particular film. Once in the cinema commentary, cheering, speaking on the phone and reacting to on-screen activity are all entirely acceptable; they are indeed encouraged as part of the collective experience of enjoying a film. For example, during a screening of a film in the supernatural horror franchise *Paranormal Activity*, a scene in which a young girl was investigating a strange noise elicited shouts of 'Nah boy, you let she go see what dat noise is? Yuh real big man!' and 'I ain't goin' to see what dat is! Nah, if I goin', I taking a cutlass⁶ wit meh!' The performative banter and humour that are part of everyday interaction also become a key element of the cinema experience, where much of the enjoyment is derived from competitive commentary by audience members, especially young men who are with their girlfriends or friends.

Relative to its limited production of film and television shows, Trinidad has an immense advertising industry. Television and cinema adverts are accompanied by a plethora of billboards along the country's main highways depicting local celebrities, models and pop stars. Advertising, unlike programming, is local in representation, even if adverts are selling international products.⁷ McFarlane-Alvarez calls advertising in Trinidad 'microcinema', as it employs the conventional process of filmmaking with production, writing, shooting and editing. And although advertising is outside of the mainstream entertainment industry, it makes locally produced cultural patterns visible. Moreover, as McFarlane-Alvarez notes, for a population of 1.3 million people, there are some 60 registered advertising companies, 20 of which provide full advertising services (including filming commercials).⁸

The locality that is portrayed in advertising is often one that is seen as distinctly Trinidadian, featuring recognisably local landscapes.⁹ Audiences also relate to adverts in terms of their potential for bacchanal – the local term for a particularly Trinidadian-inflected version of gossip and scandal. In a study of advertising, Miller gives the example of an on-screen family sitting down to dinner. In bacchanal, viewers would

typically dispute the ethnicity of the children in relation to the appearance of the parents, implicitly questioning the paternity of the children.¹⁰ Such instances highlight how advertising draws on themes and appropriate norms and social idioms that are well-known within Trinidadian culture. Bacchanal has always been a prominent theme in mainstream media produced in Trinidad, appearing anywhere from street quarrels to advertising, and its significance helps to explain the wide appeal of soap operas in the country.¹¹

During the final months of field work in 2014, the most popular soap operas were not so much daytime soaps as higher-production primetime dramas such as *Devious Maids* and *Scandal*. Women could be heard talking about these programmes in the local grocery shop, and posts about episodes equally appeared on Facebook as users commented on the latest instalment or a particular character (Fig. 2.1). These prime-time dramas evoke a highly specific sense of Trinidadian culture, including the use of bacchanal in their storylines. They fill the later time slot of 8.30 pm, whereas the most popular viewing time is around 6 pm with the nightly news and real-life crime shows.

Trinidad's very recent history has been characterised by an increase in crime rates, mostly murder, banditry and kidnappings. There has always been a social consciousness around crime, but the sharp rise in violent gang and drug-related incidents, which produced record high murder rates of 550 in 2008, 508 in 2009 and 480 in 2010 respectively, resulted in government action in the form of a State of Emergency, declared between August 2011 and December 2011.¹² Everyday crime is reported heavily in the media, with evidence captured by CCTV, security cameras and smartphones testifying to a 'truth' that Trinidad is a dangerous place. Across the duration of field research (2011–14), videos captured on smartphones circulated on Facebook showing fights in secondary schools. Individuals commented on whether or not they knew the families and the films inflamed moral debates around bullying (discussed further in Chapter 5). Distinct from primetime television shows that are scripted, acted and produced, programmes such as *Crime Watch* (whose format is a compilation of real-life crime caught on CCTV and other surveillance devices) have gained popularity.

As well as crime and other instances that provoke moral discussion, issues that appear in newspaper headlines relating to politics are often discussed in terms of bacchanal. The vocabulary of bacchanal and scandal relates to a larger theme of spectacle and visibility in Trinidadian public life, and resonates with its media history. In recent decades print media publications with titles such as 'The Bomb', 'The



Fig. 2.1 Commentary on the television show *Scandal* posted to Facebook

Heat' and 'The Punch' have emerged, combining semi-pornographic images of women with tabloid news stories taken from international media. As Trinidadian news programmes and papers already regularly report violent crime, the type of news and images circulated online can be regarded as a more graphic extension of the sensationalism typical of such print or television media.

Yet as more homes acquire multiple devices with internet connectivity, the choices of forms of entertainment have also increased. Media consumption in the home has been transformed by digital devices and high-quality broadband, both of which impact upon the way the family watches television. As has been observed of trends elsewhere, having WiFi, laptops and tablets in the home has altered distinctly how parents and children spend time together (or do not).¹³ The imposition of specific television shows by commercial programming meant that families previously had little choice in what they watched together, or at what time. Smart televisions and Netflix, by contrast, offer the possibility for different family members to watch what they choose on different devices, so the television in the common space no longer poses a source of conflict or disagreement. It may thus appear that watching television has become a more individualistic experience. However, multiple devices have also become incorporated into the shared experience of how the family watches television, as illustrated by the following account.

The Alleyne household is a warm, loud and energetic one. Most evenings there are no fewer than seven people at home: the parents, their four children, Mrs Alleyne's sister and her three year-old daughter,

as well as the partners of the two eldest children, now in their twenties and thirties. Briana is the second youngest child, now in her final year of high school. She attends one of the schools in El Mirador and so is the first to arrive home in the afternoon. The family had subscribed to Netflix a year earlier and Briana enjoyed being able to watch any film she wanted after school. She started watching complete seasons of programmes when she saw that Netflix screened whole series, always wanting to continue a show she had started viewing until the end.

The most significant example of this was *Breaking Bad*. Briana had missed the entire series when it had peaked in its popularity as it was never aired regularly on Trinidadian television; although many of her friends had downloaded and discussed it, she had never seen a single episode. After the hype around the show's finale had cooled and conversations about its ending faded, Briana decided to watch the series from the beginning after school. She started with one or two episodes when her brother and sisters arrived home before dinner. After a season, she began watching more after her family went to bed and she could sleep in the lounge room. Her brother Nathan started teasing her, claiming she was addicted to the show; every time he wanted to watch something after finishing his homework around 11 pm, Briana was still watching *Breaking Bad*. He began to sit with her and quiz her about the plot line. At first Nathan was just trying to annoy his sister, but then he too became engrossed, posing genuine questions about the characters and events. Briana kept telling him to be quiet, so Nathan established his own routine of watching the show from the beginning, on his own laptop in bed after finishing his homework. He caught up with Briana in just over a week and the two of them started quarrelling with their older sister Josie and her boyfriend when they wanted to watch *Breaking Bad* for hours after dinner. The central characters of Walter White and Jesse began to filter their way into Briana and Nathan's conversations. They quoted one-liners from the show and shared in-jokes. Josie and her boyfriend started to feel excluded, so they too watched the first episode and continued with the series on Josie's laptop in her bedroom.

Briana and Nathan decided that the fair thing to do was to stop watching the show until the others had caught up. Two weeks later the siblings had all reached the same point and watched the remainder together, viewing it continuously for hours into the night. Their mother, Rachel, a nurse and shift worker, came in to investigate why 'these children all quiet quiet in the TV room all of a sudden'. Netflix had also begun to transform her own leisure hours; after finishing work, all she wanted

to do was 'go on her bed' and watch *Desperate Housewives* on her laptop. When her husband came home, they would watch a film together.

When Rachel saw her children watching *Breaking Bad*, she would stand in the doorway and ask them questions. 'What is Tuco doing now? Has Gus come in? What happened to Jesse's girlfriend?' Shouts of 'MUMMY!! Go away! Don' say anything!' would ensue, followed by numerous 'steups', a noise Trinidadians make by sucking through their teeth to express disdain or disapproval. As much as Rachel enjoyed teasing the kids, she eventually returned to her room to watch her own show, while Briana observed mockingly of her conservative Pentecostal mother, 'you know Mummy does watch *Breaking Bad*', followed by 'steups'.

Having Netflix and WiFi allowed the Alleynes to spend more time together amid lives that were becoming increasingly separated by routines of study and work. Although they initially watched shows according to their own time schedules and personal genre preferences, they ended up watching television in much the same way as they had prior to these new media – that is, viewing the same show, together and at the same time, so as to be able to share conversations about it. In effect, television itself became a prominent form of social media.

Some (numerical) media figures and the social media landscape

The household questionnaires that were conducted as part of field work concentrated on four areas of the town that were ranked from levels one to four (lowest to highest) in terms of income. The intention was that 25 per cent of respondents would reflect each of these income categories, at least approximately. The figures that follow are from the results of these initial questionnaires (described in the Appendix).

In terms of connectivity, there are now fewer houses in the area with landline connections; the decline in landlines has also resulted in an increase in household broadband connections. For instance, among 100 participants, 56 per cent stated that they did not own a landline connection, the most common reason being that these non-owners had moved recently (in the last five years) and, since they already owned a mobile phone, did not see the need to install a landline as well. Sixty-seven per cent of respondents reported that they subscribed to an internet connection at home, which seems to correspond to having a higher income (see tables at the end of the volume). Of those surveyed, 52 per cent

did not own a household desktop computer, 36 per cent confirmed they owned one and 12 per cent stated that they had two or more. By contrast, 23 per cent of respondents said that they did not have a laptop in the home, 35 per cent said that they had only one and 42 per cent said that they had two or more. The figures for laptop ownership are strongly influenced by the state-sponsored 'one-laptop-per-child' initiative, in which children attending primary and secondary schools are provided with laptops to take home. For many adults who had never been confident with their own computer literacy, the 'one-laptop-per-child' programme gave them their first access to a digital device in the home.

For households without landlines or broadband connections in Trinidad, affordable mobile phone contracts or pay-as-you-go plans are the main source of internet connection. Here the questionnaire generally reflected a much higher level of investment in mobile phones. Twelve per cent of those surveyed had between one and two phones in their household, with 68 per cent reporting that they owned between three and six and 20 per cent responding that they had a total of six. Indeed, the number of phones in a household often exceeded the number of people.

In terms of social media usage, the dominant platform throughout the duration of this three-year study was Facebook. Most participants who own a smartphone or use the internet regularly for work or leisure have also created a Facebook account. Although there were fewer regular users by the end of field work in 2014 as compared to 2012 most had retained their account, even if they claimed they no longer checked it as often. Parents in the over-45 age bracket had been introduced to Facebook by their teenage or young adult children. The parents used Facebook primarily to keep in touch with relatives living abroad, as most Trinidadians, irrespective of background or income, would know at least one or two distant relatives overseas, the most common destinations being the UK, US and Canada.¹⁴

Throughout the research, only one user of social media over the age of 60 was involved in the study and she proved to be an exceptional case in several respects. Aged 80, she regularly used Skype and Facebook and confidently researched her interests on Google throughout the day. More generally, adults over the age of 40 had been quite slow to copy younger users and adopt social media; most created a Facebook account only around 2012.

While Facebook is used extensively, this is not the case for Instagram. Twitter is also far less common in El Mirador.¹⁵ The next chapter examines the strong class dimension of social media usage,

whereby those who from more middle class backgrounds tended to use Instagram as well as Facebook and those from the lower middle classes used only Facebook. There was also a tendency to post individual interests on Instagram and more group-oriented content on Facebook. At the beginning of field work in late 2011 BBM (BlackBerry Messenger) was the most popular instant messaging platform, partly because BlackBerry at the time was the most popular smartphone, by far the least expensive option for those who wanted access to web browsing through WiFi. By the end of 2012 both BBM use and BlackBerry ownership were in decline, the Samsung Galaxy providing a powerful rival, compared to the still less affordable iPhone. At that time, too, WhatsApp was replacing BBM as the instant messaging platform of choice. WhatsApp had copied most of the attractive features of BBM, but was not restricted to a particular brand of phone. By the end of field work in 2014 WhatsApp had become popular throughout Trinidad, a development discussed in more depth in Chapter 4.

One of the main reasons given by respondents for not using Twitter was its limited messaging size of 140 characters per post. Yet also, although it is called a social network, Twitter was introduced primarily as a means of access to news and interest-based information, making it appear less 'social'. Information shared on Twitter therefore seemed socially decontextualised. Rather than focusing on who passed on the information, which in El Mirador is an important factor in giving credibility to information, the emphasis is on the information itself. Twitter represents the antithesis of what people in a small town such as El Mirador view as the proper way for information to be disseminated, namely through its social context. Only those who had developed a more abstract relationship to information embraced Twitter, one example being Tahlia, a university graduate who had returned home from living on campus to work in a government office. As she noted in relation to her reasons for leaving Facebook in preference for Twitter:

Everyone is on [Facebook]. Anyone can add you and see all your business and you see what they doing and so much of it is nothing anyway. You need a bit more for Twitter. You need to find some interesting news or follow people who are in the know and you can retweet them. You need to be a bit clever. Also, I control who can follow me, I don't want 50,000 followers on Twitter. I think I have about 70 followers, I know some people but never met others. I follow them as well and they just tweet about things I'm interested in. Nothing about their personal lives and all that.

What appeals to Tahlia is the wider dissemination of content, where her main agenda is looking at what she finds interesting, regardless of who posted it. Her focus is on information and efficiency, rather than the spread of gossip and opinions. By contrast Sasha, who we encountered in Chapter 1, tried almost every social media platform as each gained popularity. However, she stopped using Twitter only a couple of months after joining. As she explained:

I find Twitter boring. First, there's hardly no one on it, everyone's on Facebook. So I share pictures and update my status and there's not as many people to see it, I don't know if they like it, what's the point? And then all these people who you don't know can follow you. And they posting things and I know nothing about them. I have around 2,000 friends on Facebook, I have chatted to almost everyone, I like their status or their pictures, I know something about them.

Those such as Sasha, who in this respect would be quite typical of El Mirador, may well share some content around national issues or local news on Facebook, but it is never far removed from the world view of the person sharing it. As such, the tight-knit nature of community life 'offline' in a small town is replicated 'online' through the visibility of community on Facebook. (However, by the end of the field work, Facebook was also in decline, possibly due to its being rather too well socialised, as we shall see.)

With regard to other channels of communication, email is rarely used; it remains very much a work or study medium that individuals speak of using infrequently. Even in schools, where students' main channel for contacting teachers is email, it remains second or third in rank as compared to Facebook and Skype. One teacher described how students feel more comfortable with the informality of Facebook and Skype. If they are experiencing some problems with understanding content from a class, they prefer to ask in dialect over social media rather than having to formulate questions in proper English for a more formal medium such as email. Increasingly common among work peers is WhatsApp, which has replaced email for quick questions that need a prompt reply. Colleagues are aware that their peers carry their phones on them at all times and will respond to the audio alert of the message. Generally Trinidadians do not regard being able to contact their work peers through various media as any kind of intrusion, nor does the choice of medium seem significant in itself. The exceptions are those who work in

professional roles and complain when they feel they are being contacted frequently, either by a work colleague, friend or acquaintance, for no particular reason – or most obviously, out of boredom. There were also fewer than five research participants who owned a LinkedIn profile and used it regularly.

Prior to email, letter writing was a popular pastime among Trinidadians, especially writing to friends and family overseas. If people were not avid letter writers, then correspondence would be reserved for special occasions, such as Christmas. For the generation now aged 45 and above, the exchange of greeting cards was significant for commemorating special events, as well as for acknowledging significant relationships. Among this same age group, having pen-pals had been quite common. With an increased use of the internet, greeting cards migrated to e-cards and now on Facebook, we see a genre of post which also replicates the greeting card, as is discussed in the next chapter.

What people do on Facebook

Since 2009 Facebook usage has become more common in Trinidad, with 96 per cent of respondents to our questionnaires having created their profile between 2009 and 2012. Before Facebook, the most commonly used social media platforms were HiFive and, to a lesser extent, MySpace. MSN was used extensively for chatting, as was ICQ before that, but these platforms were not intended for functions such as circulating images. The questionnaire results afforded insights into the frequency of posting, sharing, liking and commenting, and it was concluded that there are two extremes – those who make considerable use of Facebook and those who do very little. For example, in terms of postings per day, 21 per cent of respondents said that they post (which consists of liking, sharing or commenting: in effect, any interaction beyond browsing) less than ten times a day, while 57 per cent post more than 60 times a day. This leaves only 21 per cent of people posting with a frequency that could be called the middle ground. With respect to posting images taken with a phone or camera (as opposed to posting a meme or image that was created or modified by someone else), 81 per cent of people surveyed said they post less than ten photos per month.

A similar frequency occurs with posting a status, where 20 per cent said they rarely post a worded status, if ever, and 50 per cent post fewer than ten status updates per month. In terms of commenting there

are similar extremes, with 38 per cent commenting less than 10 times a month and 39 per cent of respondents commenting more than 60 times a month. Only nine per cent of respondents comment between 11 and 60 times per month. 'Liking' is the most popular activity, with 49 per cent of people surveyed 'liking' posts or photos from others more than 60 times a month. Sharing is the least popular activity, with 47 per cent saying that they shared content less than ten times a month.

In terms of the primary Facebook activities – posting, commenting, sharing and liking – what emerges can be described as a spectrum of visibility. The relative few who post regularly are more inclined to post a status update or share images of themselves, with photos emphasising personal style or lifestyle and more revealing posts sharing feelings or thoughts. Commenting, as a direct interaction with what someone else has posted, is much more popular. However, the most popular form of interaction on Facebook is the gentle acknowledgement and benign participation of 'liking' others' posts. Facebook activity as a spectrum of visibility, that is posting, commenting, sharing and liking, also relates to the idea of social visibility introduced in Chapter 1. Individuals consciously bring to the fore some aspects of themselves for display, while obscuring others. The result is that some individuals appear eye-catching or attention-grabbing, while others simply remain a passive presence.

Facebook and its cultural 'fit' with Trinidad

Facebook has remained the dominant social media platform in Trinidad because of its resonance with more 'traditional' forms of communication. Image sharing affordances make Facebook a highly visual medium which accords with Trinidadians' shared understanding of the forms and implications of visibility (a theme which is the focus of Chapter 5). Carnival, for example, is the highlight of the cultural calendar, characterised by revellers' ability to 'free up' and 'play themselves' – albeit in costume and in designated spaces at that time of year alone. What people choose to make visible and its consequences form a kind of visual language in which Trinidadians are entirely fluent. Facebook in turn reproduces (at least) two notable local social phenomena around social life and visibility: *macoing* and *bacchanal*.

'Maco' ('to maco' and 'macoing') is the colloquial term for poking into somebody else's business, usually without permission. Through formal and informal discussion and observation, it became clear that one of the primary uses for Facebook is *macoing*. Informants spoke

about macoing in relation to Facebook with a sense of humour and light-heartedness. Yet the consequences for the person who is the subject of macoing can be less frivolous, often extending to stress and anxiety.¹⁶ Informants talked most openly about macoing friends or people they know quite well and with whom they spend a lot of time. Checking friends' profile pages was viewed as the most harmless form of macoing, as the person would see what the other had been doing and later bring up the activities reflected in their posts as a topic of conversation, in a light and humorous way. Macoing ex-partners and their new partners was also very common: for example, seeing if they are happy or not, what the new partner is like and criticising what they are wearing or their hairstyles. The other most common function of macoing resonates with what has been written more generally about the psychological consequences of Facebook: users look at the pages of those they see as rivals or competitors, for example, an old school mate or work colleague, or somebody who they might have known in the past, but currently do not know very well at all.¹⁷ When asked about this type of macoing in the form of the question 'Do you have a Facebook nemesis?', or somebody who they maco a little too much, respondents would at first laugh and deny it. Yet when pressed a little further, some respondents (mostly women) would reveal that yes, there is someone on Facebook of whom they are little jealous. The types of posts that aroused jealousy were mostly along the theme of 'the grass is always greener' – namely, images of upmarket places visited in Trinidad, images of holidays or life abroad, outfits and generally glamorous lifestyles.

The potential for such content to evoke envy is the exact reason why it is shared and indeed, most respondents admitted to posting for the same reason. Cultivating looks and appearance is important and many would therefore never countenance posting a photo of themselves looking scruffy and unkempt, a finding which echoes Nicolescu's observations in *Social Media in Southeast Italy*.¹⁸ Through this emphasis on macoing, Facebook becomes an extension of an already existing theme in Trinidadian social life. The more frustrating consequences of macoing, meanwhile, relate to family members and family surveillance and will be discussed in depth in Chapter 4.

As was noted earlier, the local idiom 'bacchanal' for Trinidadians connotes confusion and scandal. Yet simultaneously bacchanal also has the potential to uncover truth. Facebook and, more recently, WhatsApp are spoken about as having the capacity to both provoke and facilitate bacchanal through textual conversation and the circulation of images. This perhaps emerges most often in the arena of personal relationships,

where a status update or image might cause a controversy which then unfolds outside of Facebook. This potential for bacchanal is typified in the story of Sharon and Nikesh.

Sharon is 34 and has two daughters. She went out to Port of Spain for an evening with her friends, while her husband Nikesh invited some friends over to lime. Most of his friends at the time of research were young fathers like himself, as Nikesh only married Sharon two years earlier and was still getting used to juggling work, his own family and, now, his in-laws. Sharon was a former Carnival Queen who had been accustomed to enter the competition every year. A group of volunteers in one of El Mirador's masquerade camps would make her costume (and those of all the others) for that year's carnival. She no longer enters the competition, but has remained friends with the same masqueraders: they still like dancing and 'getting on bad' (having a good time), so every few months they go into the city for a night out. Nikesh likes to lime and drink, but is not really keen on dancing, preferring to stay in with his 'partners' (friends) to 'drink a beer and play PlayStation'. That night he recounted to his friends how he had found his mother-in-law particularly overbearing during the week. As he told the boys about it, a few of them exchanged similar stories about their in-laws; how they could be critical or controlling and were always poking into their business. Having had a few beers by this point, Nikesh picked up his phone and posted a Facebook status: 'I gettin rel (real) sick of this shit an one day ppl gonna hear it'. From one perspective, the update seemed rather vague – no one could really know what he was talking about, beyond the fact that he seemed annoyed about something. Yet the message did appear to be indirectly aimed at someone (a kind of status update that forms a whole distinct genre in Trinidad, as discussed in Chapter 4). On the other hand Sharon, who was on the way home from town at 2 am, checked Facebook and knew exactly what Nikesh was referring to. She called him straight away and asked him to remove the update, hearing the guys in the background and knowing immediately from Nikesh's voice that he had had quite a few drinks. 'I'll deal wit yuh when I come back,' she told him and hung up the phone.

When she arrived home an hour later, the boys had left and Nikesh had calmed down, so she asked him again to remove the update, explaining that, 'I know yuh vex, but dis gonna make a whole mess if everybody seeing it'. Although the discussion between Sharon and Nikesh did not occur online, by posting the update Nikesh had revealed the extent of his frustration with his in-laws. Both Sharon and Nikesh's friends saw the status update at 2 am, but members of their extended family only

checked Facebook after they woke up the next morning and so remained blissfully unaware of Nikesh's grievances.

Posting on Facebook runs the risk of the user becoming the subject of bacchanal – the most common form of which is a man being photographed with a woman who is not his partner. The image itself on Facebook will not usually elicit controversial comments from peers. Rather, the confrontations and arguments typically occur offline and the photo is later removed. Jordan, a university student in his early twenties, noted the hazards around Facebook's potential to cause bacchanal:

People started posting statuses about other people, but in an indirect way. So that's what you call bacchanal, which is caused because of the pictures. Facebook plays a major role in this, the bacchanal was only noticeable to people in the group before Facebook, but now, because of Facebook, everybody knows, which makes the whole thing more embarrassing for some people. They call it 'Macobook' or 'Fasbook', that's why people like me, I tend to limit how much people can see on my profile, I don't put up big wall posts or statuses, pictures are taken of me a lot but if I don't like a certain picture of me, I'll just tell my friend to take down the picture. I wouldn't say that I limit my Facebook because of that, I limit my interactions with certain people so that they don't affect my Facebook. If it's a situation where somebody is causing bacchanal on my Facebook, I either remove them or totally ignore them. There are some Trinidadian people who love bacchanal, we love to party and we love bacchanal, that's a fact, ask anybody.

Yet, in relation to public issues, newsworthy stories or politics, much of the bacchanal that follows does play out online, a theme which is the focus of Chapter 6. Throughout the field work, there were at least four instances of videos going viral and making the national news. One example was of a fight between a group of girls that occurred after school and another was of a mother giving her daughter 'licks' (a form of corporal punishment using a belt to strike a child). Both videos were widely circulated and commented upon. Their appeal lay in the shocking nature of the images: they were a spectacle, but also provoked moralising discussions about children. The videos attracted thousands of shares and hundreds of comments, which in turn incited moral debates around such issues as the way children are raised 'nowadays' and the importance of religion in home life, alongside broader racial commentary. Commentators on Facebook are easily identifiable, using their

real names and open privacy settings, suggesting that individuals are quite comfortable about posting opinions on a public issue. Similarly when a political scandal makes national headlines, whether it is the Prime Minister taking her nephew to the World Cup in Brazil or a sex scandal featuring a former member of parliament, Facebook users are quick to respond with moral commentary, or in the case of politics, with humour.¹⁹

Over the course of field work, there appeared to be a decline in the use of Facebook to post photos, share status updates or leave comments. Although Trinidadians tend to post more images on Facebook than the English, for example, public posting generally declined between 2012 and 2014.²⁰ The most common reason for this less frequent posting, coupled with an increased uptake of WhatsApp (among owners of a smartphone), was precisely that using Facebook left people too open to becoming the subject of *macoing* or *bacchanal*. Even where there is no immediate misunderstanding around a post, the conversation that it generates commonly results in some unrelated but unpleasant truth being revealed, if not believed.

It is not surprising, then, that understanding *macoing* and *bacchanal* is central to appreciating the local meaning of Facebook and its various appropriations in Trinidad.²¹ Locating Facebook within discussions of *macoing* and *bacchanal* also appears to explain its initial popularity. Yet at the same time it is possible to see in this very alignment and cultural resonance the causes of Facebook's more recent decline in this country. Where everyone recognises *bacchanal* as a constitutive aspect of being Trinidadian, it also reflects a relationship with the past and the traditional character of 'Trini' society.²² *Bacchanal* inevitably has the potential to cause harm and so people have always been ambivalent about it – enjoying it when it is at other people's expense, but less sanguine when the subjects of it themselves. For those now trying to advance toward what they see as a more modern Trinidad, one more closely resembling other metropolitan countries, the capacity of Facebook to promote *bacchanal* may well be something they initially welcomed and enjoyed, but over time may have also come to regret.

Facebook's cultural fit with Trinidad neatly encapsulates the idea of social visibility, showing the process whereby norms around visibility come to be established. The effect of *bacchanal* as a social mechanism for keeping others in check is to deter people from putting themselves 'out there' or too much in the public view. Images are interpreted as testifying to a truth, but, since truth is malleable, they can often be misinterpreted to suit somebody else's agenda. For these reasons many tend

to avoid posting very personal updates or images that can be misread, though there are exceptions to this when a post is intended to send an explicit message to a person or a group of people. What individuals choose to reveal of themselves will be subject to the scrutiny of others. Similarly, however, social and moral judgements are made concerning which platforms individuals use for communication. The theory of polymedia therefore becomes particularly relevant at this point.

Polymedia

Throughout the field work a number of anxieties were expressed, mostly by parents, that interaction between ‘people nowadays’ is becoming less meaningful because of new media. For example, Laetitia, a woman in her fifties, lamented in relation to her teenage son:

I feel sorry for these children, the times is so different, yuh can’t go out all hours of the night walk back, yuh jus’ go to school an’ come home, go to school an’ come home. So they jus’ textin’ all the time and chatting, they don’t get to spend time together anymore.

Behind the idea of polymedia lies a prior assumption that expresses the anthropological roots of the concept. Anthropology recognises that all communications between people are and must be mediated – either through technologies or norms of appropriate conduct, such as how an employee would speak to his or her boss or an aunt to her nephew.²³ The mediation that takes place through communications media simply adds another layer on to these already mediated relationships.²⁴ Uses of different media forms are influenced by a number of factors, including features of the media itself, the content of the conversation and the relationship between the parties. WhatsApp allows you to send text and voice messages, for instance, while Skype allows you to video call a person and simultaneously type a message to them. Yet the choice of platform would depend on the relationship and the topic of conversation.

The opening volume of this series, *How the World Changed Social Media*, discusses how each subsequent book employs a concept of polymedia in relation to the field site. Polymedia recognises that, with a relative decline in concern for cost and access, individuals are instead judged according to their choices between different media. The consequences of this choice have the effect of resocialising

media, where media is expressive of social relationships as well as the ecology of different communications technologies. The emergence of polymedia therefore depends on shifts in access, affordability and literacy.²⁵ In El Mirador mobile phone plans (monthly or prepaid) and access to WiFi are sufficiently affordable to be ubiquitous. Cost is even less of an issue with WiFi hotspots, and the increase of WiFi access has also made the cost of texting through mobile phone plans far more competitive.

Many also choose to use a certain platform based on their previous media experiences. Although email is predominantly used for work in El Mirador, those who used email regularly outside of a work context likened emailing to sending letters. As one young woman, whose best friend had moved to New York, recounted:

I definitely use long emails, like the friend who is not here, at least the most juicy communication that is take place between us, is in long email. Even jus' recently she tell meh, I have a drama to tell you. I tell her on Facebook, I am waiting I'm impatient, and she tell meh and she send meh a long email in part 1 and part 2 and everything in detail in the entire scenario, like we would not do that on Facebook just for some reason in email it's easier. It's like keeping letters, to me that is a nice thing, to keep these things documented and to look back on it.

In contrast an older woman, a stay-at-home mother who never used email regularly, described how she used Skype to communicate with a childhood friend who has lived overseas for some time:

She is living there now, she is married and has a family there now. Before I used to write a lot of letters, before this came in. I love to write. So I find when webcam came in or whatever, before I would write and write but then computers came in with technology and then I say ok, although I love to type, I'm not a big expert you know, sometimes I'm talking to you through Skype or whatever, and I talk, sometimes you talk and you may not understand, so I'll send messages.

These brief examples illustrate how the use of email or Skype has been compared to the experience of writing letters, and how specific relationships have shaped the usage of both. Also relevant here is the fact that prior to 'polymedia' there was no clear term to capture how one media

could be embedded in another or how multiple technologies converge in a single device. Cameras are now integrated into most phones, and the texting function within the web calling program Skype means that one can interchange between talking, texting and sending images in the same conversation.

As discussed further in Chapter 4, polymedia emphasises how individuals are judged according to their choices of digital technology for maintaining relationships: each technology finds its place not only in relation to another, but also within the context of relationships.²⁶ Families are inherently structured around relationships, but choice, including that of which media to communicate with, is also an extended expression of care and concern insofar as it aims to preserve relationships. While social media as it relates to personal relationships is a relatively complex interaction, commercial uses of social media in El Mirador are far more straightforward.

Commercial uses of social media

El Mirador has a relatively small online presence. Thousands of residents have individual profiles on Facebook, but pages for town affiliations, groups and businesses are rare. There are several pages for El Mirador's local high schools and alumni, but fewer for its handful of clubs such as Rotaract (an offshoot of Rotary International). Some owners of small businesses have used Facebook (and to a lesser extent Instagram and LinkedIn) to promote their businesses by creating a page dedicated to the business or changing their own cover photo to the company's logo. Young bar owners who try to market their business to a more media-savvy crowd update their online events and news regularly, for example, in the same way that large bars, restaurants and venues market themselves in Port of Spain.

In other parts of the country, Facebook has been one of the more effective means of attracting business through direct marketing. Among the leisure and entertainment industries large chain cinemas, such as the IMAX in an upmarket area of Port of Spain, regularly display their film session times on Facebook. Nightclubs advertise promotions, where prospective patrons can Facebook message or call promoters on their personal mobile phones to reserve tickets. Restaurants and bars frequently update their pages with drink specials for Fridays and Saturdays, where patrons can likewise send inbox messages to RSVP. Similarly, chain clothing shops will post photos of new clothes and specials on Facebook,

where customers can reserve their pieces to be picked up later. In more metropolitan Trinidad it would now be quite unusual for Facebook not to play a prominent role in any given commercial venture.

Yet the same social media marketing strategies have not been so successful in El Mirador. There are virtually no pages advertising local businesses, aside from a couple of bars whose young owners have invested large sums in refurbishing to attract a younger, more fashionable crowd and who have themselves worked for other ventures in Port of Spain. The reasons behind the lack of success in marketing local businesses via social media may relate to the concepts introduced in the preceding chapter, namely digital resistance. For example, 'D' Corner is the most successful bar for young people in El Mirador. It is located at the end of the high street, away from the centre of the town, but on Friday and Saturday nights the crowd spills outside the bar/nightclub venue on to the street. Here young men can be found drinking, smoking and talking to young women who have invested considerable effort in their hair, make-up and outfits. The busiest night is the last Friday of the month, when patrons have received their monthly pay. Throughout the year, promotional models from the town representing the local brewery and branded alcoholic drink companies distribute flyers at 'D' Corner for theme nights at other bars and clubs in the area, also sharing promotional images on their personal Facebook profiles. The crowd at 'D' Corner commutes from the surrounding villages as well as the town proper, though there is nothing particularly unique about the venue. Despite this there are only two posts on the bar's Facebook page, set up on 26 December 2013; the last dates from 27 December 2013 and only 166 people have 'liked' the page.

An interesting comparison may be made with another popular local bar, Margharitaville. This bar closed at the end of 2013 and reopened four months later with its premises fully renovated; it now boasts an extended outdoor area and dance floor, comfortable lounges and free WiFi. Yet it draws a much smaller crowd and has not retained the momentum it had prior to renovation, even though its Facebook page has 877 'likes' and the venue posts updates frequently with promotions, theme nights and drink specials. Indeed, since Margharitaville revamped its image clientele numbers have actually dropped, with the bulk apparently migrating to 'D' Corner.

By trying to emulate the popular style of bar found in Port of Spain, Margharitaville seems to have deterred its patrons: they do not identify with the urban, cosmopolitan ambience and prefer the less pretentious feel of a country town bar. Those in El Mirador who would normally

be attracted by ambience, fashionable décor and WiFi are more inclined to opt for a night out in Port of Spain, rather than a night in a Port of Spain-styled bar in El Mirador. At least eight other business owners said that they had tried marketing their business on Facebook, but gave up after a short time as they saw it was not enhancing their business. As the centre of El Mirador spans a short distance, the length of the high street can be walked in 20 minutes; in contrast to the urban hubs of Port of Spain or San Fernando, one does not need to travel for 45 minutes or more from other parts of the country to reach its night spots. Advertising on Facebook is perhaps therefore more relevant to patrons who have to cover longer distances, since information in El Mirador is passed just as quickly by word of mouth as through Facebook promotion. The leisure and entertainment habits of residents of the town and surrounding villages are fairly regular, with the same groups frequenting the same places, again making the promotion of new offers on social media somewhat irrelevant.

Although few businesses in El Mirador regularly maintained a commercial Facebook page, a number of participants acknowledged the importance of Facebook pages for commerce. One woman whose friend ran a local catering business commented that ‘Everybody got to have a page, otherwise your business don’t exist. Another friend is always telling me to go to her page and like it. But I know what business she has, why should I like the page on Facebook? Everybody knows what she selling’. Facebook provides visual evidence that businesses are successful if they have attracted several ‘likes’, and it is often these ‘likes’ that count most for prospective patrons – not the regularly posted news or updates. But simultaneously, as in the case of Margharitaville, a business that appears to be successful on Facebook may rather represent a performance of success, not actually reflected in its commercial results.

Even more surprisingly, technology-oriented businesses such as mobile phone stores, internet cafés and computer repairs and sales also generally opt out of social media advertising. One internet café owner attributed his refusal to maintain a business page to the low level of computer literacy in the region. As he explained, ‘most people only use the internet for Facebook and for games. It’s more important to be connected on Facebook than to do research on Google. Most of the clients here [at the internet café] might do a little homework for school or if they take an evening course but other than that, the social network (like Facebook) is more important than getting information’.

El Mirador and the digital inclusion debate

The above comments reflect the ongoing debate in El Mirador around digital divides and the lack of computer literacy. Even though there are several WiFi hotspots around the town, and programmes such as 'one laptop per child' have increased internet usage among its population, most prefer to use the internet to cultivate social networks through platforms such as Facebook, rather than to seek information or conduct research. The statistical data and formal and informal discussions with participants which informed the findings of this field work may have important implications for policy making. For example, policy around the role of technology in building social networks and social capital often emphasises the circulation of knowledge and information toward a better use of resources for economic opportunities.²⁷

Field work conducted in Trinidad by Sheba Mohammad, who is also involved in the Why We Post project, provides another important source of data on the impact of social media in education – in particular, on online education and the role of informal learning through platforms such as YouTube. Mohammad led the team which developed the first online learning network in the Caribbean, *knowledge.tt*,²⁸ integrating learning materials into an e-learning hub that can be easily accessed by the general public. Her passions and expertise around online education evoked a number of conversations about why there seems to be a knowledge gap in El Mirador. Here the segment of the population with higher incomes uses the internet for accessing knowledge and information, whereas those with lower incomes are less inclined to.²⁹ The existing research and related arguments around developing effective online education tools for Trinidad and Tobago suggested that the town of El Mirador was among those places where broader national strategies would either not apply or would be unlikely to work.

Evidence for this could be found in the manner in which the internet generally appears to be used among young people in the town. For example, students in private or prestigious schools, whose parents are able to send them to after-school classes, are more likely to use internet resources for research and school assignments, as well as for entertainment and social media. Many of these students have parents with a high level of computer literacy, who use digital media as part of their own professional and vocational lives.³⁰ On the other hand, in less affluent schools where some teachers are confident in computer literacy but others are not, there is less focus on students developing online research

skills. Here students primarily use their laptops for accessing social media and entertainment. These trends in computer literacy are also generally reflective of class differences in the town itself: those from more middle-class backgrounds espouse more middle-class values around the internet as a tool and resource for furthering education and existing skills. In contrast people with lower incomes or non-professional jobs are less inclined to want to increase their computer literacy.

Three participants specialising in areas of formal and informal education reiterated the divide in El Mirador in terms of using the internet for education and circulating knowledge and information. The first, Sherene, is a primary school teacher; she has over 25 years of experience working in schools in the area and is also the former principal of a small primary school on the outskirts of the town. Kumar is the owner of an internet café whose business also incorporates computer courses, laptop repairs and sales, while Valerie is the director of a local NGO specialising in school holiday programmes and after-school and weekend classes in digital literacy and effective job seeking. Sherene explained that:

There is a sort of gap, between parents and teachers in what they think about computers for learning, which flows on to the students. The children who come from homes where the parents and maybe older brothers and sisters who use the internet for study, they see this behavior regularly and they copy it. If children only see the computer used for Facebook and music videos and YouTube, they think it's just for entertainment, like the television.

Similarly, Kumar noted that the main reason the majority of his customers first come into the internet café is to ask how to set up an email account and then how to join Facebook. They later become regular customers who mainly use their internet time for chatting. His second largest market is gamers, most of whom have internet access at home and are computer literate, but choose to visit the internet café for the sociality it provides, where they can physically game among peers. The smallest clientele base for Kumar is high school, vocational and adult students who come into the café to use internet-based resources for their studies. Requests for printing are extremely frequent, but requesting internet time to research assignments is less common. This may be due to students having internet connectivity in their homes, though the majority of patrons (apart from gamers) in Kumar's venue do not subscribe to household access. He explained that the café is one of the main digital centres in the region – as is apparent from how busy it is daily,

with most of the 40 computers occupied during peak hours – and that the vast majority of requests are for Facebook and YouTube access, rather than general information.

Another perspective is given by Valerie, who co-founded a resource centre with the owner of another computer repairs shop. They now receive modest sponsorship from the Trinidadian government and various international NGOs that specialise in ICT4D (internet communications technologies for development). They run regular classes after school, teaching high school students how to use Microsoft Office applications and the internet for research. Due to the external sponsorship, these classes cost very little compared to private after-school classes that complement formal studies, and so the participants are predominantly from lower-income households surrounding El Mirador. Valerie observed that:

Most of the kids that come to lessons have a laptop but don't really use it for school work. Also, the laptops are shared with the rest of the family. They might take it to a relative's house and use their internet access for Skype or Facebook other things, so it's not like the laptop belongs to the child alone. They also don't really see the use of the internet. I mean, I use it for everything and I teach my kids that it's a tool but not all kids comes from homes with the same mindset. It's really hard to change that. The kids grow up with all sorts of influences from the parents and they turn out the same.

Although Valerie's perspective also reflects a moral value around education and the home, her comments, alongside those of Sherene and Kumar, reinforce the view that the digital divide in El Mirador is related to perceptions of the value of the internet for education, rather than an access or infrastructural divide.³¹ These participants and others, particularly parents, frequently connected the value of building information networks with the need for learning and training. These views endorsed initiatives such as 'one laptop per child', while observing that such projects must also emphasise developing and valuing computer literacy.

Conclusion

This chapter has provided an overview of the dynamics around social and mainstream media as the main tools for exploring social visibility in Trinidad throughout the rest of the volume. The data outlined above

serves as a snapshot of local internet and communications infrastructure, though this chapter also explores how existing social relations prior to digital media have now extended into digital usage – for example, local idioms such as ‘maco’ and ‘bacchanal’ can be equally applied in describing uses of social media.

With regard to non-commercial uses of Facebook, ‘maco’ and ‘bacchanal’ reflect the primacy of social visibility as a way of keeping people in check, where expressing or documenting oneself controversially results in public scrutiny and gossip. Visuality in the form of posting images or status updates attests to a certain truth in a given situation, yet that truth is also disputable and can become subject to speculation. On Facebook, truth is a construction. Individuals invest considerable effort in curating their profile with posts and photos because, as noted earlier, for Trinidadians a person’s identity is evidenced visually through the labour they undertake in creating themselves.³² But visuality as truth also operates in other ways, as seen in the example of commercial uses of Facebook. For businesses that have been operating in the town for several years, a Facebook page does not necessarily assist in increasing business. Similarly, a new business which has attracted a number of ‘likes’ may not be as successful as an older one, even though its Facebook page seems to provide evidence of a thriving concern.

The issue of divides is a complex one in El Mirador, making the concept of polymedia especially useful in this context. In relation to cost and infrastructure, there is a clear increase in the proportion of the local population owning several digital devices and possessing a broadband connection in the home. The town has several WiFi hotspots and initiatives such as ‘one laptop per child’ have resulted in households having access to at least one computer. The contribution of this book is therefore to reveal how issues which today seem pertinent are not so much related to concrete infrastructure as to the social dimensions of ‘networks’. As increasing access and accessibility for more peripheral populations worldwide becomes ever more central to the agenda of policy makers, ‘building networks’ becomes relevant to debates around digital divides.³³ A context-based study of social media also illustrates how the more recent shift from debates around digital divides to digital inclusion emphasises types of usage, rather than the availability of access.³⁴

This chapter builds on the concept of ‘digital resistance’, a term that was introduced in Chapter 1 and will gain further traction in Chapter 5, alongside arguments concerned with the social logic of visibility in Trinidadian society. Like other non-Western societies, Trinidad is a place where relationships, and regular acknowledgement of those

relationships, are central to social cohesion. It is still a country where saying 'good morning' or 'good day' after boarding a bus or taking a seat in the waiting area of the bank is important. Information is not simply regarded as useful facts; it is deeply entwined in the logics and values of the people who circulate it.

'Networking', for example, does not necessarily imply expanding one's own networks, but rather maintaining and positively acknowledging them, a concept which also relates to an urban-rural divide. In El Mirador networks mean family, friends and community, built on a sense of shared values, while networks from Port of Spain or other big cities are viewed as based on work and interests. These urban-based networks are determined more by the individual. For rural people who live in close proximity to one another and whose networks overlap with others', forming relationships simply for the sake of sharing resources, skills or information is viewed as taking advantage where it does not also entail extending the care, concern and acknowledgement that comes with being part of a 'community'.

Because maintaining networks and acknowledging relationships are so important, individuals must also decide which communications media they use, taking into account their relationship to the other party and the content they wish to convey. The norms of conduct and expectations around choosing the appropriate media for the correct purpose are still becoming established. What might be acceptable for one person may not be for another, for example, having phones on the table at a dinner with friends. Accordingly, the common theme throughout this chapter has been to highlight social context and polymedia as the factors which determine the fate of respective social media and their uses. These were the factors behind Facebook's flourishing in the town as well as its current decline, and which also explain why Instagram and Twitter have not been embraced significantly. So too, these factors can shed light on the relative lack of importance around social media in commerce and the problems of establishing internet-based free education in the area. Overall one might have expected that the intense sociality of a small town such as El Mirador would have been fertile ground for the intense sociality of social media. Yet the results have been much more nuanced. The reasons why social media initially takes off are often the same reasons why there has been a collective resistance or reluctance to embrace it, in the face of these potential social transformations.

The chapter has also emphasised the importance of sociality to Trinidadian life. Whether it is a film in the cinema, a television programme or a photo posted by an individual, the media product is simply